WEEK 4 – INFORMATION SEEKING IN THE ELECTRONIC ENVIRONMENT

INTRODUCTION

The emergence of Information and Communication Technology (ICT) has significantly altered how people search for, access, and use information. In the traditional library environment, information seeking was largely limited to printed materials such as books, journals, card catalogues, and reference tools physically housed within the library building.

However, with the advent of computers, the internet, electronic databases, digital libraries, and online search tools, information seeking has moved beyond physical boundaries into what is now referred to as the **electronic environment**. In this environment, users can search for information anytime and anywhere, provided they have access to electronic devices and internet connectivity.

Understanding how information seeking occurs in the electronic environment is essential for library and information science students because librarians are no longer just custodians of books; they are facilitators of digital access, search skills, and information literacy.

MEANING OF INFORMATION SEEKING

Information seeking refers to the **conscious and purposeful effort** made by an individual to locate information in response to a specific need. It is a process that begins when a person recognises a gap in their knowledge and ends when that gap is filled, partially or fully.

In the context of library and information science, information seeking is not random. It involves **strategic actions**, such as identifying sources, selecting appropriate tools, searching systematically, evaluating retrieved information, and applying it to solve a problem or support decision-making.

Information seeking behaviour differs from one individual to another depending on factors such as educational background, ICT skills, access to resources, and purpose of the search.

THE ELECTRONIC INFORMATION ENVIRONMENT

The electronic information environment refers to the **digital space** where information is created, stored, accessed, and disseminated using electronic technologies. This environment is characterised by the use of computers, mobile devices, networks, databases, and internet-based platforms.

Unlike the traditional library environment, the electronic environment is:

1. Not limited by physical location
2. Capable of storing vast amounts of information
3. Highly dynamic and constantly changing
4. Interactive and user-driven

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Examples of electronic information environments include:

Online databases

Digital libraries

Institutional repositories

Search engines

E-learning platforms

Social media platforms

Libraries now operate simultaneously in both physical and electronic environments.

NATURE OF INFORMATION SEEKING IN THE ELECTRONIC ENVIRONMENT

Information seeking in the electronic environment differs significantly from traditional information seeking.

Firstly, it is **self-directed**. Users often search independently without direct assistance from librarians. Secondly, it is **non-linear**, meaning users may jump from one source to another through hyperlinks. Thirdly, it is **interactive**, allowing users to refine searches, filter results, and save information.

Electronic information seeking also involves dealing with:

Information overload

Multiple formats (text, audio, video, images)

Issues of credibility and authenticity

Subscription barriers and access restrictions

As a result, users require higher levels of digital and information literacy.

STAGES IN INFORMATION SEEKING IN THE ELECTRONIC ENVIRONMENT

Information seeking in the electronic environment follows a systematic process, even though users may not always be conscious of it.

Recognition of Information Need

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This is the first and most critical stage. The user becomes aware that they lack certain knowledge required to complete a task, solve a problem, or satisfy curiosity. For example, a student realising they need journal articles for an assignment.

Definition and Clarification of the Need

The user then defines what type of information is required. This includes deciding:

The subject area

The depth of information needed

The time frame

The format (articles, books, statistics)

A clearly defined information need leads to more successful searching.

Selection of Appropriate Electronic Sources

The user decides where to search. Possible sources include:

Search engines

Library OPAC

Academic databases

Digital repositories

Institutional websites

Librarians play a key role in guiding users to authoritative sources.

Formulation of Search Strategies

At this stage, users develop search terms and strategies. This involves selecting keywords, synonyms, and subject terms, and deciding how to combine them using search techniques.

Searching and Retrieval

The user enters search queries into electronic systems and retrieves results. These results may include hundreds or thousands of documents, requiring further refinement.

Evaluation of Retrieved Information

Not all retrieved information is useful or reliable. Users must evaluate:

Authority of the author

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Credibility of the source

Accuracy of content

Currency of information

Relevance to their need

Use and Application of Information

Finally, the user uses the information for its intended purpose—writing assignments, conducting research, making decisions, or expanding knowledge.

TOOLS FOR INFORMATION SEEKING IN THE ELECTRONIC ENVIRONMENT

Information seeking in the electronic environment relies on several ICT-based tools.

Search Engines

Search engines such as Google and Bing allow users to search the World Wide Web. While they are easy to use, they often retrieve information of varying quality.

Online Public Access Catalogue (OPAC)

OPAC enables users to search the holdings of a specific library electronically. It is more structured and authoritative than general search engines.

Electronic Databases

Databases such as JSTOR, EBSCOhost, ProQuest, and ScienceDirect provide access to scholarly and peer-reviewed materials.

Digital Libraries and Repositories

These platforms store digitised and born-digital content, including theses, dissertations, and institutional publications.

Social and Academic Networking Platforms

Platforms such as ResearchGate and Google Scholar also support information discovery, especially in academic environments.

SEARCH TECHNIQUES IN THE ELECTRONIC ENVIRONMENT

Effective electronic information seeking requires the use of search techniques.

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Keyword Searching

This involves using important words related to the topic. Choosing appropriate keywords improves retrieval quality.

Boolean Logic

Boolean operators such as AND, OR, and NOT help refine searches by combining or excluding terms.

Phrase Searching

Placing words within quotation marks retrieves exact phrases, reducing irrelevant results.

Truncation and Wildcards

These techniques retrieve variations of words and expand search results.

Use of Filters and Limiters

Filters such as date, document type, language, and subject help narrow search results.

ROLE OF LIBRARIANS IN ELECTRONIC INFORMATION SEEKING

In the electronic environment, librarians function as:

1. Information guides
2. Digital literacy trainers
3. Database instructors
4. Search strategy advisors
5. Evaluators of information quality

Libraries support users through user education programmes, online guides, tutorials, and virtual reference services.

CHALLENGES OF INFORMATION SEEKING IN THE ELECTRONIC ENVIRONMENT

Despite its advantages, electronic information seeking presents challenges such as:

1. Information overload
2. Difficulty evaluating credibility
3. Digital divide
4. Limited access to paid databases
5. Poor internet connectivity
6. Lack of search skills

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These challenges make the role of the librarian even more important.

IMPORTANCE OF INFORMATION SEEKING SKILLS IN THE ELECTRONIC ENVIRONMENT

Strong information seeking skills:

- Improve academic performance
- Enhance research quality
- Promote lifelong learning
- Reduce plagiarism
- Support informed decision-making

Libraries contribute to national development by equipping users with these skills.

CONCLUSION

Information seeking in the electronic environment represents a major shift from traditional library use. It is faster, broader, and more complex. While ICT has made information more accessible, it has also increased the responsibility of users and librarians to search intelligently, evaluate critically, and use information ethically.

A library that effectively supports electronic information seeking remains relevant, responsive, and essential in the digital age.

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